FOR THE PERSON PLAYING THE INTERVIEWER

You don't need to know anything about consulting.

This binder gives you everything a real interviewer has: what to say, what information to hand over and when, what a good answer sounds like, and how to score it. Your partner does the thinking. You hold the facts and keep the clock.

What a case interview is, in 30 seconds

Consulting firms test candidates with a short business puzzle, called a **case**. You read out a client's problem, for example "a hot dog stand is losing money, why?". The candidate has to ask good questions, organize the problem, do some math out loud, and end with a clear recommendation. It's a test of **how they think**, not of business trivia.

Your job, in one line each

- **Read** the blue *Say* lines out loud, word for word if you like.
- **Answer** questions using the *If they ask* tables. Anything not on the list: "Not important for this case, make an assumption."
- **Hold back** the yellow *Give* boxes until the moment described. Never volunteer data early.
- **Tick** the *Listen for* boxes as you hear them. That is your evidence for scoring.
- **Never show** the green *Answer key*. It's for you to check the candidate's numbers.
- **Score** at the end with the rubric, then give feedback: 2 strengths, 2 things to fix.

The colors in every case

SAY

Words you read out loud.

GIVE ONLY WHEN…

Data you hand over (read it, or show this box) only when the trigger happens.

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

The right numbers and what a strong answer contains.

IF THEY'RE STUCK

Hints in order. Give one, wait 30 seconds, then the next.

HOW TO STEER

What the casebook says to do at this point, e.g. "after their framework, tell them the problem is only internal." Follow it so the case goes where it should.

FULL LIST · ASK IF THIN · IF THEY SAY…

A complete checklist to tick (so you see exactly what they missed), follow-up questions to dig deeper when an answer is short, and replies to common mistakes. Use probes before hints: probes make them think, hints give the answer away.

ADDED PARTLY ADDED mark steps, data and answers that go beyond the original FlashFash case. A line under the step says exactly what was added.

Before you start (2 minutes)

- [ ] Pick a case you haven't read with them. Start with an **Easy** one.
- [ ] Read the case once to yourself, start to finish (about 5 minutes).
- [ ] Give the candidate paper, a pen and a calculator-free zone (no phone calculator; real interviews don't allow one).
- [ ] Sit across a table. Start a timer. Aim for 20–25 minutes per case.
- [ ] Keep a straight, friendly face. Real interviewers don't react much.

THE SIX STAGES

Every case follows the same shape

Each case script below walks you through these stages. Knowing the shape helps you notice when the candidate skips one.

1 **You read the prompt**

Read slowly. A good candidate writes it down and then repeats it back in their own words. If they don't, tick it as missed.

2 **They ask clarifying questions**

Usually 2–4 questions: about the goal, the client, the market. Answer from the *If they ask* table. More than ~6 questions is too many.

3 **They build a framework**

They'll ask for a minute or two of silence. Say "Sure, take your time." Then they explain how they'll break the problem into parts (for example "revenue" and "costs"). Compare with the Answer key.

4 **Analysis and math**

They ask for data, or estimate it themselves. You give the yellow boxes. They calculate out loud. You check against the Answer key.

5 **Insight: "so what?"**

After each number, a strong candidate says what it means for the client. If they don't, ask: "What does that mean for the client?"

6 **Recommendation**

You say the closing line. They should give the answer **first**, then 2–3 reasons, then risks and next steps. Under a minute.

Timing guide for a 25-minute case

Stage	Target	If it runs long
Prompt + questions	2–3 min	"Let's get going. What's your approach?"
Framework	2–4 min	"Which part would you look at first?"
Analysis and math	10–15 min	Give the next hint from the script.

Recommendation	1–2 min	"In one sentence: yes or no?"
Your feedback	5 min	Rubric + 2 strengths, 2 fixes.

Golden rules

1. Make them ask

Data comes out only when they ask for it, or when the script says "give if their estimate is way off". Asking for the right data is part of the test.

2. Let them estimate first

Many cases are **candidate-led**: they should make up reasonable numbers first. Only give the real number if theirs is far off (each script says what "far off" means), or if they ask directly.

3. Don't confirm too fast

When they get a number right, say "Okay, keep going." When it's wrong, say "Can you double-check that?" Never tell them the right number until they've tried twice.

4. Silence is fine

When they ask for time, give it: real interviewers wait. Only speak up after about 60 seconds of total silence.

5. Push back once

Once per case, ask "Why?" or "Are you sure?" even when they're right. It tests whether they stay calm and can defend their logic.

6. Hints in order

If they're stuck, use the red hint boxes one at a time. Every hint you give costs a point on "Drive" in the rubric. Note how many you gave.

Phrase bank

They ask for time to think	"Sure, take a minute."
They ask something not in your script	"Good question, but it's not important here. Make a reasonable assumption."
They ask "Is that right?"	"What do you think?" or "Walk me through how you got there."
They're silent for a long time	"Can you walk me through what you're thinking?"
They ramble or go off-track	"Let's focus. What do you need to answer the client's question?"

They finish a calculation and stop	"So what does that mean for the client?"
They made a math mistake	"Can you double-check that last step?"
They ask you to just give the number	"What would you estimate?" (Give it if the script says so.)
Time is running out	"The CEO just walked in. What's your recommendation?"

USE THIS FOR EVERY CASE

Scoring rubric

This case's five skills

FlashFash tests each skill with one question: **Structuring** (question 1) → Structure. **Numeracy** (question 2) → Math. **Judgement and insights** (question 3) → Business sense. **Creativity** (question 4) → Business sense and Drive. **Synthesis** (question 5) → Communication.

Score each area from 1 to 5. A 3 means "would probably pass at a first-round interview". Use the ticks from the case script as evidence. Be honest: a generous score doesn't help them.

Area	1–2: Weak	3: Pass	4–5: Strong
Structure	Jumps into numbers with no plan. Framework is a generic list or misses big pieces.	Clear framework with 2–4 parts that fit the case. Some overlap or gaps.	Framework is tailored to this client, has no overlaps or gaps, and is explained in under 2 minutes. Says which part to look at first and why.
Math	Wrong answers, messy, silent working, or needs a calculator.	Correct with maybe one slip they fix themselves. Talks through steps.	Fast, correct, clean units (per day, per year, $M). Rounds sensibly and announces each step out loud.
Business sense	Reports numbers without meaning. Misses the key insight even after hints.	Explains what numbers mean when asked. Finds the insight with one hint.	Says "so what" on their own, sanity-checks results ("that seems high because..."), spots the key insight unprompted.
Communication	Hard to follow, rambles, recommendation is vague or missing.	Clear enough. Recommendation exists but is buried or long.	Answer-first, organized ("three reasons: first..."), confident, under a minute to close.
Drive	Waits for you to lead. Needed 3+ hints.	Mostly leads. Needed 1–2 hints.	Leads the whole case, asks for the right data at the right time, suggests next steps. No hints needed.

Reading the total (out of 25)

- **21–25**: Offer-level. Move to harder cases.
- **16–20**: Solid. Fix the lowest area.
- **11–15**: Getting there. Redo this case type in a few days.
- **5–10**: Practice the basics: frameworks and mental math.

How to give feedback (5 minutes)

1. Ask them first: "How do you think that went?"
2. Share **2 things they did well**, with specific moments ("you compared LaMode's 4.2% Asia target with its 3% share at home").
3. Share **2 things to fix**, again specific ("you didn't say what $48 vs. $42 meant for the deal").
4. Read them the total score and their lowest area.

PLAIN-ENGLISH GLOSSARY

Words the candidate will use

You don't need to use these. It just helps to know what they mean when you hear them.

Framework / structure	Their plan for breaking the problem into parts.
MECE	"Mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive": parts that don't overlap and together cover everything. Interviewers love it.
Revenue	Money coming in. Usually price × quantity sold.
Costs: fixed vs. variable	Fixed costs don't change with sales (rent). Variable costs grow with each unit sold (food in each hot dog).
Profit	Revenue minus costs.
Profit margin	Profit as a % of revenue. $10 profit on $100 revenue = 10% margin.
COGS	"Cost of goods sold": what it costs to make the product itself.
Payback period	Years needed to earn back an investment. Investment ÷ yearly profit.
Breakeven	The point where revenue exactly covers costs (profit = 0).
Market sizing	Estimating how big a market is, e.g. "how much is spent on diapers per year".
Market share	The % of a market one company holds.
Market entry	A case about whether a company should start selling in a new market.
Barriers to entry	Things that make it hard to enter a market: licenses, laws, big competitors.

Cross-selling	Selling a second product to an existing customer.
Sanity check	Asking "does this number make sense?" before moving on.
Price elasticity	How much customers buy less when the price goes up.
"So what?"	What a number means for the client's decision.

PICK ONE

The cases

Read the script once on your own before you begin. Each takes 15–25 minutes plus 5 minutes of feedback.

FlashFash

Mergers & acquisitions · Medium · ~30 min

CASE 1 OF 1

FlashFash

Mergers & acquisitions | Medium | ~30 min

WHAT THIS CASE IS ABOUT (READ THIS YOURSELF)

A big US clothing company (FlashFash, $25B revenue, mid-market brands, very fast production) is thinking about buying LaMode, a fast-growing online seller of luxury fashion. The candidate structures the decision, tests whether LaMode's Asia growth plan is realistic, judges the synergies from a data exhibit, brainstorms growth ideas, and makes a recommendation.

THE ANSWER IN ONE LINE, DON'T SHOW

Don't acquire LaMode. Its Asia plan needs **~4.2%** of the Asia online apparel market (above its 3% at home); synergies are **weak**: LaMode's customers are far more premium ($413 vs. $78 per purchase), FlashFash already sells more online ($5B+ vs. $2B), and LaMode's $48 transaction cost exceeds FlashFash's $42 margin per purchase. Only real synergy: helping LaMode expand internationally. Next: scan for other targets with a strong presence in Asia.

1 Read the prompt

2–3 min

SAY

"Our client is FlashFash, a US multinational apparel company with $25 billion of revenue. The company owns some of the best-known mid-market brands. It sells 70% of its products through its own stores, and 30% through multi-brand retail chains."

"FlashFash has a unique business model: instead of committing a large share of production for the next fashion season, it commits a small amount, and uses customer feedback and an efficient production network to replenish stores with new products weekly. New styles take as little as 15 days to go from design to production."

"As part of its growth strategy, FlashFash is considering acquiring LaMode, the leading independent online retailer of luxury brands, with 3% of all online apparel sales in North America. LaMode curates products from the best brands into a unique collection of over 30,000 items. It recently launched its own fashion brand, which already accounts for 5% of its revenue."

"The CEO of FlashFash has asked us: should they acquire LaMode?"

"Do you have any questions before you start?"

IF THEY ASK… YOU ANSWER

What's the client's objective?	"To accelerate the growth of FlashFash, in a way that creates value for its shareholders."
Is there a price for LaMode? ADDED	"Not yet. First we need to decide whether it's worth pursuing."
What does mid-market mean here? ADDED	"Affordable everyday fashion, between discount and premium."
How fast does the CEO need an answer? ADDED	"A first view within a few weeks."
Is LaMode profitable? ADDED	"We'll look at its economics shortly."
Anything else	"Not important for this case. Make an assumption."

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Plays back: $25B mid-market apparel company, fast model, considering an online luxury retailer
- [ ] Asks for the objective (growth that creates shareholder value)
- [ ] Notes the contrast: mid-market vs. luxury, stores vs. online

▼ Show example answer

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> **Let me make sure I understand.** FlashFash is a $25 billion mid-market apparel company, mostly selling through its own stores, with a very fast, demand-driven production model. It's considering buying LaMode, the leading independent online luxury retailer, with 3% of North American online apparel sales and a young own brand. **The question is whether to acquire it.** Could I ask: **what's the client's objective** with this deal? And is there a price yet? **Could I take a minute to structure my thoughts?**

2 Framework

3 min

SAY

"How would you structure your approach to the problem?"

HOW TO STEER

- Original case: if asked, or if the candidate goes off-track, share that the client's goal is to accelerate the growth of FlashFash in a way that creates value for its shareholders.
- This is an interviewer-led case: after the framework, you lead to each question in order.

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Value and growth potential of LaMode on its own
- [ ] Whether FlashFash can use LaMode to boost sales and cut costs (synergies)
- [ ] Whether FlashFash can execute the deal and integration

FULL LIST FROM THE ORIGINAL FLASHFASH CASE: TICK WHAT THEY COVERED

- [ ] Value & growth: growth of the online apparel market
- [ ] Value & growth: LaMode's market share
- [ ] Value & growth: LaMode's costs
- [ ] Revenue synergies
- [ ] Cost synergies
- [ ] FlashFash's capability to execute

ASK IF THEIR ANSWER IS THIN

- "How would you know if LaMode is worth buying on its own?"
- "What could FlashFash bring to LaMode, and LaMode to FlashFash?"
- "Even if it's a good deal, could FlashFash pull it off?"

IF THEY SAY... YOU SAY

Only talks about LaMode's market	"What about how the two companies would work together?"

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

1. Value and growth potential of LaMode: growth of online apparel, LaMode's market share, costs. **2. Can FlashFash use LaMode to boost sales and reduce costs?** Revenue synergies, cost synergies. **3. Does FlashFash have the capability to execute?**

IF THEY'RE STUCK: ONE HINT AT A TIME

1. "What would make LaMode a good acquisition?"
2. "Think about LaMode alone, then the two together."

▼ Show example answer

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. Restate the decision
2. Bucket 1: LaMode's value and growth alone
3. Bucket 2: synergies, revenue and cost
4. Bucket 3: ability to execute
5. Check in

Phrases to listen for: "To decide whether to acquire LaMode, I'd look at three areas." · "Does that sound good?"

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> **To decide whether to acquire LaMode, I'd look at three areas.** **First, LaMode's value and growth potential on its own**: how fast online apparel is growing, LaMode's market share, and its cost structure. **Second, whether FlashFash can use LaMode to boost sales and reduce costs**: revenue synergies, like cross-selling or international expansion, and cost synergies, like sourcing and fulfillment. **Third, whether FlashFash can execute**: integrating an online luxury business is very different from running mid-market stores. **Does that sound good?**

▼ **Book's 8-bucket version also counts**

If the candidate uses the 8 buckets from *Hacking the Case Interview*, this is a strong version. Credit it like the casebook's framework.

Market attractiveness

- Online apparel growth (global, Asia)
- Luxury vs. mid-market trends

Financial considerations

- LaMode's growth (31%) and cost structure
- Is the Asia plan realistic?
- Price vs. value created

Synergies

- Revenue: international expansion, cross-selling
- Cost: fulfillment, sourcing, own-brand COGS

Company capabilities

- Can FlashFash run online luxury?
- Integration risk

Very close to the case's 3 buckets: the book's Synergies bucket is the case's middle bucket. Add 'customers: luxury vs. mid-market' as a sub-bullet, because that's what kills cross-selling.

3 Asia market share

4–5 min

SAY

"The client believes LaMode could make a third of its global sales in Asia within five years, as the apparel market in Asia is expected to double and the share of purchases made online to triple over this period."

"What share of the Asia online apparel market would LaMode need to reach to capture this opportunity?"

HOW TO STEER

- Original case: let the candidate ask for the data below, but share it even if they don't ask.

GIVE ONLY WHEN: WHEN THEY ASK, OR AFTER THEY LAY OUT THEIR APPROACH.

- LaMode's global sales are **$2B**, and are expected to **triple** over the next 5 years
- The online apparel market in Asia today is **$8B**

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Sets up the formula first: LaMode Asia sales in 5 years ÷ Asia online market in 5 years
- [ ] LaMode Asia sales = (3 × $2B) ÷ 3 = $2B
- [ ] Asia online market = $8B × 2 × 3 = $48B
- [ ] Share = $2B ÷ $48B ≈ 4.2%

IF THEY SAY… YOU SAY

Uses today's $8B market	"What happens to the Asia online market over the five years?"
Grows the market ×2 or ×3, not both	"Both the total market and the online share are changing."
Uses $6B for Asia sales	"Is that LaMode's global sales, or its Asia sales?"

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

```
Share in 5 yrs = LaMode Asia sales ÷ Asia online market
LaMode Asia sales = (3 × $2B) ÷ 3 = $2B
Asia online market = $8B × 2 × 3 = $48B
Share = $2B ÷ $48B ≈ 4.2%
```

IF THEY'RE STUCK: ONE HINT AT A TIME

1. "What two numbers do you need to divide?"
2. "What will LaMode's global sales be in five years, and what's a third of that?"

▼ **Show example answer**

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. Write the formula in words first
2. Numerator: LaMode's Asia sales in 5 years
3. Denominator: Asia online market in 5 years (×2 × ×3)
4. Divide and state the share

Phrases to listen for: "Let me set up the formula first." · "The market grows six times: it doubles, and the online share triples."

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> **Let me set up the formula first.** LaMode's share in five years equals its Asia sales in five years, divided by the Asia online apparel market in five years. LaMode's global sales triple from $2 billion to $6 billion, and a third of that is Asia, so **$2 billion**. The Asia online market is $8 billion today; the total market doubles and the online share triples, so it grows six times, to **$48 billion**. **$2 billion divided by $48 billion is about 4.2%.**

4 Sanity check PARTLY ADDED

2 min

Beyond the original FlashFash case: The comparison with LaMode's 3% is in the case's answer; asking it as its own question is added.

SAY

"What do you make of that number?"

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Compares with LaMode's 3% share in North America, its core market where it's well established
- [ ] Calls the 4.2% target extremely ambitious
- [ ] Draws the implication: the Asia plan doesn't justify the acquisition

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

The client's expectations imply LaMode would capture 4.2% of the Asia online apparel market in 5 years. That's extremely ambitious, given its share of its core market, where it is well established, is just 3%. At this stage it doesn't look like FlashFash should acquire LaMode on the basis of its Asia growth plans.

IF THEY'RE STUCK: ONE HINT AT A TIME

1. "How does 4.2% compare with LaMode's share at home?"

▼ Show example answer

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. Verdict first
2. Benchmark: 3% at home
3. So what for the deal

Phrases to listen for: "It looks extremely ambitious." · "So what: the Asia plan on its own doesn't justify the acquisition."

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

It looks extremely ambitious. LaMode holds 3% of online apparel in North America, its core market, where it's well established. **The plan asks it to reach a higher share, 4.2%, in a market where it has zero sales today.** **So what:** the Asia growth plan on its own doesn't justify the acquisition.

5 Synergies

5–6 min

SAY

"The client would like you to look at synergies. We've compiled this exhibit with information about both our client and the target."

"Let me know your thoughts on whether there are potential synergies that seem appealing, based on this information."

HOW TO STEER

- If asked, share that transaction costs include the cost of order fulfillment, customer service, payment processing and returns.
- Give them a minute to read the exhibit in silence before they talk.

GIVE ONLY WHEN: RIGHT AWAY (EXHIBIT 1).

Exhibit 1.

Global sales, $M	FlashFash	LaMode
Total	25,400	2,014
North America	9,500	1,802
Europe	8,600	212
Asia	5,000	0
Rest of world	2,300	0
Annual growth	4.2%	31.3%
Online presence	**FlashFash**	**LaMode**
% sales online	22%	100%
Transactions	**FlashFash**	**LaMode**
Average purchase	$78	$413
Cost of goods sold	46%	72%
Transaction cost	$6	$48
Own brand, $M	**FlashFash**	**LaMode**
Total sales	25,400	104
Cost of goods sold	11,684	63
Annual growth	4.2%	123.4%

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Walks the exhibit table by table, not at random
- [ ] International: FlashFash's experience outside North America could accelerate LaMode abroad
- [ ] Online: FlashFash already sells more online in dollars than LaMode
- [ ] Customers: LaMode is far more premium (5× average purchase), so little cross-selling
- [ ] Distribution: LaMode's transaction cost is above FlashFash's margin per purchase
- [ ] Own brand: FlashFash could help LaMode's COGS, but it's a small cost

FULL LIST FROM THE ORIGINAL FLASHFASH CASE: TICK WHAT THEY COVERED

- [ ] Use FlashFash's international experience to accelerate LaMode abroad
- [ ] FlashFash sells more online than LaMode in absolute terms (22% × $25B ≈ $5B > $2B): no online expertise to gain
- [ ] LaMode is much more premium (average purchase ~5× higher): limited cross-selling
- [ ] LaMode can't distribute FlashFash profitably: $48 transaction cost > $42 margin
- [ ] FlashFash might cut LaMode's own-brand COGS, but it's a small category

ASK IF THEIR ANSWER IS THIN

- "Which company sells more online, in dollars?"
- "How different are their customers?"
- "Could LaMode sell FlashFash's products profitably?"
- "Where is LaMode present, and where is FlashFash?"

IF THEY SAY… YOU SAY

"LaMode brings online expertise"	"Compare their online sales in dollars, not percentages."
"They can cross-sell to each other's customers"	"Look at the average purchase. Are these the same shoppers?"

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

- International: FlashFash's experience outside North America could accelerate LaMode's international growth.
- Online: FlashFash already sells more online than LaMode (22% × $25B ≈ $5B > $2B), so it gains no online expertise.
- Customers: LaMode is clearly more premium (average purchase 5× higher), so cross-selling is limited.
- Distribution: LaMode can't distribute FlashFash profitably: its $48 transaction cost is above the $42 margin on a FlashFash purchase.
- Own brand: FlashFash might lower LaMode's own-brand COGS, but it's a small cost category.

IF THEY'RE STUCK: ONE HINT AT A TIME

1. "Take the exhibit one table at a time."
2. "Start with where each company sells."

▼ Show example answer

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. Say you'll go table by table
2. For each table: the fact, then what it means
3. Name the one real synergy
4. Overall verdict

Phrases to listen for: "Let me go through the exhibit table by table." · "That's the one real synergy."

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> **Let me go through the exhibit table by table.** **Geography**: FlashFash sells $16 billion outside North America while LaMode sells almost nothing there, so **FlashFash could accelerate LaMode's international growth**. That's the one real synergy. **Online**: 22% of $25 billion is about $5 billion, more than LaMode's $2 billion, so **FlashFash has no online expertise to gain**. **Customers**: LaMode's average purchase is $413 versus $78, **about five times higher**, so these are different shoppers and cross-selling is limited. **Distribution**: LaMode's transaction cost is $48, more than FlashFash's roughly $42 margin per purchase, so **LaMode can't sell FlashFash products profitably**. **Own brand**: FlashFash could lower LaMode's own-brand costs, but that's only about $100 million of sales.

6 Online expertise PARTLY ADDED

2 min

Beyond the original FlashFash case: The 22% × $25B math is in the case's answer; asking it as its own question is added.

SAY

"Let's test one claim. Some argue FlashFash would gain online expertise from LaMode. How much does each company sell online today?"

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] FlashFash: 22% × $25.4B ≈ $5.6B (the case rounds to $5B)
- [ ] LaMode: 100% × ~$2B = $2B
- [ ] FlashFash already sells 2.5–3× more online: no expertise to gain

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

```
FlashFash: 22% × $25.4B ≈ $5.6B online
LaMode: 100% × $2.0B = $2.0B online
```

FlashFash already has the bigger online business, so online know-how isn't a reason to buy.

IF THEY'RE STUCK: ONE HINT AT A TIME

1. "What percent of FlashFash's sales are online?"

▼ Show example answer

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. FlashFash online $ = share × total
2. LaMode online $
3. Compare and conclude

Phrases to listen for: "So FlashFash already has the bigger online business."

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> FlashFash sells 22% of $25.4 billion online, **about $5.6 billion**. LaMode is 100% online, **about $2 billion**. **So FlashFash already has the bigger online business**, almost three times LaMode's, and online know-how isn't a reason to buy.

7 Distribution economics PARTLY ADDED

2–3 min

Beyond the original FlashFash case: The $48 vs. $42 math is in the case's answer; asking it as its own question is added.

SAY

"Could LaMode sell FlashFash products profitably on its site? What margin does FlashFash make on an average purchase?"

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Margin = (100% − 46%) × $78 ≈ $42
- [ ] LaMode's transaction cost is $48 per order
- [ ] $48 > $42: LaMode would lose ~$6 on every FlashFash order
- [ ] Explains what transaction costs include if they asked

IF THEY SAY… YOU SAY

Uses FlashFash's $6 transaction cost	"Whose platform would the sale happen on?"

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

```
FlashFash margin = (100% − 46%) × $78 ≈ $42
LaMode transaction cost = $48 → loss of ~$6 per order
```

IF THEY'RE STUCK: ONE HINT AT A TIME

1. "What's left of $78 after 46% cost of goods?"
2. "What does it cost LaMode to process one order?"

▼ Show example answer

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. FlashFash margin per purchase
2. LaMode cost per order
3. Compare: profit or loss per order
4. Conclude

Phrases to listen for: "LaMode would lose about $6 on every FlashFash order."

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> A FlashFash purchase averages $78, with 46% cost of goods, so the **margin is about $42**. LaMode spends **$48 to process an order**: fulfillment, service, payment and returns. **So LaMode would lose about $6 on every FlashFash order**; it can't distribute FlashFash profitably.

8 Synergy verdict

1–2 min

SAY

"So overall, how strong is the case for synergies?"

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Weak overall
- [ ] Little cross-selling: very different customers
- [ ] No online expertise to gain
- [ ] The only meaningful synergy: LaMode's international expansion
- [ ] Concludes LaMode isn't a good target

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

Overall this is a weak case for synergies. There's little opportunity to cross-sell given the different customers, and FlashFash has no online expertise to gain. The only meaningful synergy is LaMode's international expansion. This confirms LaMode isn't a good acquisition target for us.

▼ Show example answer

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. Verdict first: weak
2. Three reasons
3. The one exception
4. Link back to the decision

Phrases to listen for: "Overall, the case for synergies is weak." · "That confirms LaMode isn't a good target for us."

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> **Overall, the case for synergies is weak.** The customers are too different to cross-sell, FlashFash has no online expertise to gain, and LaMode can't distribute FlashFash's products profitably. **The only meaningful synergy is helping LaMode expand internationally.** **That confirms LaMode isn't a good target for us.**

9 Organic growth

4 min

SAY

"Beyond potential synergies with FlashFash, what ideas do you have to accelerate the organic growth of LaMode?"

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Structured, e.g. products / channels / customers / geographies
- [ ] Several ideas in each group
- [ ] Uses what we know: own brand growing 123%, no presence in Asia

FULL LIST FROM THE ORIGINAL FLASHFASH CASE: TICK WHAT THEY COVERED

- [ ] New product types: jewelry
- [ ] New product types: cosmetics
- [ ] New product types: sports gear
- [ ] New product types: furniture
- [ ] New product types: data
- [ ] Sell offline: own stores
- [ ] Sell offline: independent stores
- [ ] Sell indirectly: to other brands
- [ ] Sell indirectly: to third-party distributors
- [ ] Other segments: mid-market
- [ ] Geographies: Asia-Pacific
- [ ] Geographies: Europe
- [ ] Geographies: Latin America
- [ ] Geographies: Middle East and Africa

ASK IF THEIR ANSWER IS THIN

- "What else could LaMode sell besides clothes?"
- "Does LaMode have to stay online only?"
- "Which regions is LaMode missing?"

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

1. Other product types: jewelry, cosmetics, sports gear, furniture, data. **2. Selling offline**: own stores, independent stores. **3. Selling indirectly**: to other brands, to third-party distributors. **4. Other segments**: mid-market. **5. Other geographies**: Asia-Pacific, Europe, Latin America, Middle East and Africa. Overall, many opportunities to grow LaMode beyond its current scope.

IF THEY'RE STUCK: ONE HINT AT A TIME

1. "Think about what LaMode sells, how, to whom, and where."

▼ Show example answer

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. Announce the structure: what, how, to whom, where
2. 2–4 ideas per branch

3. Use facts from the exhibit (own brand growth, no Asia)
4. Wrap up

Phrases to listen for: "I'd think about growth along four dimensions: what, how, to whom, and where."

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> **I'd think about growth along four dimensions: what LaMode sells, how, to whom, and where.** **What**: new categories such as jewelry, cosmetics, sports gear and furniture, and even monetizing its customer data, and keep pushing the own brand, which is growing over 100% a year. **How**: offline, through its own stores or independent stores, and indirectly, selling to other brands or third-party distributors. **To whom**: a mid-market line. **Where**: Asia-Pacific, Europe, Latin America, and the Middle East and Africa. **Overall, there's a lot of room to grow LaMode beyond its current scope.**

10 Recommendation

1–2 min

SAY

"Overall, what would you recommend to the client?"

LISTEN FOR: TICK WHAT YOU HEAR

- [ ] Answer first: LaMode isn't the best acquisition target
- [ ] Brands don't fit LaMode's (luxury) positioning
- [ ] LaMode can't sell FlashFash products profitably
- [ ] The Asia target implies ~4% of the market, above its 3% at home
- [ ] Next step: scan the market for alternative targets, ideally strong in Asia

ANSWER KEY, DON'T SHOW

"You asked us whether FlashFash should acquire LaMode. In our view, it isn't the best acquisition target: your brands aren't a good fit with LaMode's positioning; LaMode's economics mean it couldn't sell FlashFash's products profitably; and its five-year target implies capturing 4% of the Asia online apparel market, above its share of its core US market. Over the next two weeks, we'd like to scan the market for alternative targets, ideally with a strong presence in Asia."

▼ Show example answer

HOW A STRONG ANSWER IS STRUCTURED

1. Restate the question and answer it first

2. Three reasons with numbers
3. Next steps

Phrases to listen for: "You asked whether FlashFash should acquire LaMode. In our view..." · "Over the next two weeks, we'd like to..."

EXAMPLE ANSWER, SAID OUT LOUD

> **You asked whether FlashFash should acquire LaMode. In our view, it isn't the best acquisition target, for three reasons.** One, **your brands don't fit LaMode's luxury positioning**, so there's little to cross-sell. Two, **LaMode's economics mean it couldn't sell your products profitably**: its $48 cost per order is above your $42 margin. Three, **its five-year plan implies capturing over 4% of the Asia online apparel market**, more than its 3% share at home. **Over the next two weeks**, we'd like to scan the market for alternative targets, ideally with a strong presence in Asia.

▼ Show the full sample interview

INTERVIEWER

"Our client is FlashFash, a US multinational apparel company with $25 billion of revenue. The company owns some of the best-known mid-market brands. It sells 70% of its products through its own stores, and 30% through multi-brand retail chains."

"FlashFash has a unique business model: instead of committing a large share of production for the next fashion season, it commits a small amount, and uses customer feedback and an efficient production network to replenish stores with new products weekly. New styles take as little as 15 days to go from design to production."

"As part of its growth strategy, FlashFash is considering acquiring LaMode, the leading independent online retailer of luxury brands, with 3% of all online apparel sales in North America. LaMode curates products from the best brands into a unique collection of over 30,000 items. It recently launched its own fashion brand, which already accounts for 5% of its revenue."

"The CEO of FlashFash has asked us: should they acquire LaMode?"

CANDIDATE

Let me make sure I understand. FlashFash is a $25 billion mid-market apparel company, mostly selling through its own stores, with a very fast, demand-driven production model. It's considering buying LaMode, the leading independent online luxury retailer, with 3% of North American online apparel sales and a young own brand. **The question is whether to acquire it.** Could I ask: **what's the client's objective** with this deal? And is there a price yet? **Could I take a minute to structure my thoughts?**

INTERVIEWER · FRAMEWORK

"How would you structure your approach to the problem?"

CANDIDATE

To decide whether to acquire LaMode, I'd look at three areas. **First, LaMode's value and growth potential on its own**: how fast online apparel is growing, LaMode's market share, and its cost structure. **Second, whether FlashFash can use LaMode to boost sales and reduce costs**: revenue synergies, like cross-selling or international expansion, and cost synergies, like sourcing and fulfillment. **Third, whether FlashFash can execute**: integrating an online luxury business is very different from running mid-market stores. **Does that sound good?**

INTERVIEWER · ASIA MARKET SHARE

"The client believes LaMode could make a third of its global sales in Asia within five years, as the apparel market in Asia is expected to double and the share of purchases made online to triple over this period."

"What share of the Asia online apparel market would LaMode need to reach to capture this opportunity?"

- LaMode's global sales are **$2B**, and are expected to **triple** over the next 5 years
- The online apparel market in Asia today is **$8B**

CANDIDATE

Let me set up the formula first. LaMode's share in five years equals its Asia sales in five years, divided by the Asia online apparel market in five years. LaMode's global sales triple from $2 billion to $6 billion, and a third of that is Asia, so **$2 billion**. The Asia online market is $8 billion today; the total market doubles and the online share triples, so it grows six times, to **$48 billion**. **$2 billion divided by $48 billion is about 4.2%.**

INTERVIEWER · SANITY CHECK

"What do you make of that number?"

> CANDIDATE
>
> **It looks extremely ambitious.** LaMode holds 3% of online apparel in North America, its core market, where it's well established. **The plan asks it to reach a higher share, 4.2%, in a market where it has zero sales today.** **So what:** the Asia growth plan on its own doesn't justify the acquisition.

INTERVIEWER · SYNERGIES

"The client would like you to look at synergies. We've compiled this exhibit with information about both our client and the target."

"Let me know your thoughts on whether there are potential synergies that seem appealing, based on this information."

Exhibit 1.

Global sales, $M	**FlashFash**	**LaMode**
Total	25,400	2,014
North America	9,500	1,802
Europe	8,600	212
Asia	5,000	0
Rest of world	2,300	0
Annual growth	4.2%	31.3%
Online presence	**FlashFash**	**LaMode**
% sales online	22%	100%
Transactions	**FlashFash**	**LaMode**
Average purchase	$78	$413
Cost of goods sold	46%	72%
Transaction cost	$6	$48
Own brand, $M	**FlashFash**	**LaMode**
Total sales	25,400	104
Cost of goods sold	11,684	63
Annual growth	4.2%	123.4%

CANDIDATE

Let me go through the exhibit table by table. **Geography**: FlashFash sells $16 billion outside North America while LaMode sells almost nothing there, so **FlashFash could accelerate LaMode's international growth**. That's the one real synergy. **Online**: 22% of $25 billion is about $5 billion, more than LaMode's $2 billion, so **FlashFash has no online expertise to gain**. **Customers**: LaMode's average purchase is $413 versus $78, **about five times higher**, so these are different shoppers and cross-selling is limited. **Distribution**: LaMode's transaction cost is $48, more than FlashFash's roughly $42 margin per purchase, so **LaMode can't sell FlashFash products profitably**. **Own brand**: FlashFash could lower LaMode's own-brand costs, but that's only about $100 million of sales.

INTERVIEWER · ONLINE EXPERTISE

"Let's test one claim. Some argue FlashFash would gain online expertise from LaMode. How much does each company sell online today?"

CANDIDATE

FlashFash sells 22% of $25.4 billion online, **about $5.6 billion**. LaMode is 100% online, **about $2 billion**. **So FlashFash already has the bigger online business**, almost three times LaMode's, and online know-how isn't a reason to buy.

INTERVIEWER · DISTRIBUTION ECONOMICS

"Could LaMode sell FlashFash products profitably on its site? What margin does FlashFash make on an average purchase?"

CANDIDATE

A FlashFash purchase averages $78, with 46% cost of goods, so the **margin is about $42**. LaMode spends **$48 to process an order**: fulfillment, service, payment and returns. **So LaMode would lose about $6 on every FlashFash order**; it can't distribute FlashFash profitably.

INTERVIEWER · SYNERGY VERDICT

"So overall, how strong is the case for synergies?"

CANDIDATE

Overall, the case for synergies is weak. The customers are too different to cross-sell, FlashFash has no online expertise to gain, and LaMode can't distribute FlashFash's products profitably. **The only meaningful synergy is helping LaMode expand internationally.** **That confirms LaMode isn't a good target for us.**

INTERVIEWER · ORGANIC GROWTH

"Beyond potential synergies with FlashFash, what ideas do you have to accelerate the organic growth of LaMode?"

CANDIDATE

I'd think about growth along four dimensions: what LaMode sells, how, to whom, and where. **What**: new categories such as jewelry, cosmetics, sports gear and furniture, and even monetizing its customer data, and keep pushing the own brand, which is growing over 100% a year. **How**: offline, through its own stores or independent stores, and indirectly, selling to other brands or third-party distributors. **To whom**: a mid-market line. **Where**: Asia-Pacific, Europe, Latin America, and the Middle East and Africa. **Overall, there's a lot of room to grow LaMode beyond its current scope.**

INTERVIEWER · RECOMMENDATION

"Overall, what would you recommend to the client?"

CANDIDATE

You asked whether FlashFash should acquire LaMode. In our view, it isn't the best acquisition target, for three reasons. One, **your brands don't fit LaMode's luxury positioning**, so there's little to cross-sell. Two, **LaMode's economics mean it couldn't sell your products profitably**: its $48 cost per order is above your $42 margin. Three, **its five-year plan implies capturing over 4% of the Asia online apparel market**, more than its 3% share at home. **Over the next two weeks**, we'd like to scan the market for alternative targets, ideally with a strong presence in Asia.

Score this case

Use the ticks above and the rubric. 3 = would pass.

Structure 1 2 3 4 5

Clear, tailored framework?

Math 1 2 3 4 5

Correct, clean, said out loud?

Business sense 1 2 3 4 5

Found the insight, said "so what"?

Communication 1 2 3 4 5

Answer-first, clear, confident?

Drive 1 2 3 4 5

Led the case; few hints needed?

Total: – / 25

2 STRENGTHS · 2 THINGS TO FIX

Strength: ... / Fix: ...

OPTIONAL WARM-UP, 5–10 MINUTES

Fit questions

Real interviews often start with 2–3 personal questions before the case. Ask one or two. Good answers last 1–2 minutes and tell a story.

Ask	A good answer...
"Tell me about yourself."	A 1–2 minute story, not a CV list: studies, 1–2 experiences, why consulting, one personal detail that makes them memorable.
"Why consulting?"	Specific reasons tied to their own experience (problem-solving, variety, learning). Shows they know what the job really is.
"Why our firm?"	Names something specific: people they've met, a program, values. Not just "prestige".
"Give me an example of leadership."	A real situation, what THEY did and why, the result, and what they learned. Admits a shortcoming.
"What are your three biggest weaknesses?"	Real weaknesses, not humble-brags, each with what they're doing to improve.
"Tell me about a time you challenged yourself."	A clear challenge, the steps they took, the outcome.
"Why should we give you an offer?"	2–3 confident reasons linked to what consultants actually do.
"Why aren't you working in the field of your major?"	A positive story about moving toward consulting, not running away from their major.

Red flags in fit answers

- Over 2 minutes long
- Sounds memorized word for word
- Lists facts from the CV with no story
- Can't say why consulting specifically